Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on John Brehm's "Sea of Faith"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of the tone of Brehm's "Sea of Faith" include

allusion,
conceit,
figures of speech,
interior monologue,
irony,
metaphor,
parenthesis,
parody,
pun,
sarcasm,
simile, and
tone (wide range of tone words and phrases).

Brehm's "Sea of Faith" should elicit a wide range of responses, thus the contestant's ability to handle, not the subtle necessarily, but the distinct range of tone within the poem itself should determine the quality of the essay response to the prompt.

The contestant might choose to dwell on the sequence of allusions that charges the deep sarcasm of the teacher's interior monologue, which is framed, first, by a nod to his pleasant initial response to the student's confusion, a response in which he luxuriates in the possibilities of the teachable moment and, last, by the careful self-recriminating self-appraisal that finds the teacher in a world characterized by doubt as deep as the student's own confusion.

The contestant, knowing Matthew Arnold's "Dover Beach," might simply recognize in the teacher's own doubt the doubt admitted by Arnold's persona in the original of which Brehm's "Sea of Faith" is a species of parody.

The empathetic, maybe anecdotal response, should not be met with disdain; the situation—setting and "characters"—comprising the poem's storyline might well serve as resonance to the contestant's own youthful first steps into literary criticism. Additionally, the contestant, fancying herself or himself in front of the classroom someday might see something in the way of a cautionary tale: a witty reminder that we can unwittingly turn a young mind away from the pursuit of something that even we are yet pursuing.